5th Grade Classroom

Writing & Grammar Review Style Guide

Written by

Taylor Mantz, Elizabeth DeMercurio, Miranda Folau, Lizzie Bodily

Dear Fifth-Grade Teachers,

Welcome to the style guide for fifth-grade classroom writing and grammar review! We're so glad you are here. As teachers of this grade level, it can be overwhelming to know that you are the last stop in elementary education before your students head into middle or intermediate school. *Have they learned all they need to know? Have the years and classrooms before you prepared them for content that might not fall within your standard fifth-grade curriculum? Is there a way to help ensure they are prepared in a quick and organized manner?*

Currently, fifth-grade students enter the classroom with varying levels of mastery in writing fundamentals. This inconsistency often arises from differences in how grammar basics – such as capitalization, comma usage, and sentence structure – are taught from class to class. These inconsistencies can directly affect students' comprehension of English and their readiness as they transition into middle school. To address this, we propose implementing a unified style guide to ensure consistent instruction and support the development of confident writers. This style guide provides standardized grammar mini-lessons for fifth-grade teachers at Golden Spike Elementary to implement in the classroom.

With this style guide, you have a complete "refresher" checklist to ensure that your fifth graders are well-prepared for middle school language arts, where writing expectations become more demanding. Taking the time to review concepts they may not have learned, may have forgotten, or were not yet developmentally ready to grasp will be a meaningful gift to them.

As this style guide was created, several guiding principles shaped the process. These principles will also be important for you to follow as you implement these topics into your classroom lessons.

1. Be clear and concise—explain the writing rule, but don't overcomplicate.
2. Utilize the examples—be sure to *show*, not just *tell*.

We hope this guide helps you to plan your classroom lessons using the guidelines here and that you find it useful as a quick reference when you notice a student does not clearly understand a grammar rule. This style guide is designed to be a practical, accessible tool you can keep on hand.

We're cheering you on!
Sincerely, Pine Tree Group

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1 Core Vocabulary & Terminology

1.1 Preferred Word/Rule Set for Teachers and Students

In the fifth-grade Common Core Standards, certain words and phrases are preferred in order to "produce clear and coherent writing in which the development and organization are appropriate to task, purpose, and audience" (W.5.4). Use the following recommended words, phrases, and rules for formal student writing to support consistency for both students and teachers.

- **Specific group terms:** "peers," "students," "friends," teachers."
    - *See W.5.4, SL.5.6*
- **Gender-neutral language:** "they", "them", "theirs."
    - *See W.5.4, SL.5.6.*
- **Full phrases in formal writing**: "it is," "they are."
    - *See L.5.3.A*
- **Perfect and specific verb tenses:** "I had walked", "I have walked", "I will have walked."
    - *See L.5.1.B, L.5.1.C., L.5.1.D*
- **Proper correlative conjunctions**: "either" paired with "or", "neither" paired with "nor."
    - *See L.5.1.E*
- **Linking phrases and clauses:** "consequently", "specifically", "relevantly."
    - *See W.5.1.C., W.5.2.C.*
- **Formal concluding sentences or statements**: "in conclusion", "to conclude", to summarize."
    - *See W.5.1.D., W.5.2.E., W.5.3.E.*

1.2 List of Discouraged Terms

As noted above, the Common Core Standards emphasize using specific and formal language to maintain clarity and structure. Therefore, the following words, phrases, and practices should be avoided whenever possible.

- **Vague group terms:** “kids”, “classmates”, “people.”
    - *See W.5.4., SL.5.6.*
- **Unnecessarily gendered language or gendered language as the default**: “he/him/his,” “she/her/hers.”
    - *See W.5.4, SL.5.6.*
- **Contractions in formal writing:** “it’s, they’re.”
    - *See L.5.3.A.*
- **Imperfect/vague verb tenses**: “I walked”, “I’m walking”, “I will walk.”
    - *See L.5.1.B, L.5.1.C., L.5.1.D.*
- **Non-correlative/improperly paired conjunctions:** “either…nor,” “neither…or”
    - *See L.5.1.E.*
- **Using arguments or personal language (“I,” “me”) to link information, opinions, and reasons** instead of formal transitional phrases.
    - *See W.5.1.C., W.5.2.C.*
- **Informal concluding statements:** “the end,” or similar casual phrases.
    - *See W.5.1.D., W.5.2.E., W.5.3.E.*

1.3 Reference for Homophone Pairs/Tricky Words

(from L.4.1.g and L.5.1)

Homophones—words that sound the same but have different meanings—are a frequent challenge for students at this grade level. The chart below provides pairs or trios of sound-alike words with clear definitions for student and teacher reference.

Homophone A	**Homophone B**	**Homophone C**
By — location, close to	**Buy** — to purchase	**Bye** — short for goodbye
Their — possessive, belonging to	**They’re** — contraction of “they” and “are”	**There** — adverb, refers to a specific location

Write — to mark with a pen or pencil	**Right** — correct, the opposite of wrong	**Right** — the opposite of left
To — shows direction or destination; may also be used in letters to show who the message is meant for	**Too** — means also or excessively	**Two** — the number after one; may also mean amount or quantity
Flower — refers to a plant	**Flour** — refers to the ingredient	N/A
Hole — a hollow part in a solid object; a circle-shaped ditch	**Whole** — refers to the entire solid object cohesively	N/A
Pair — a group of two	**Pear** — a juicy fruit	N/A
Peace — a synonym of calm	**Piece** — part of the whole	N/A
Capital — an uppercase letter	**Capitol** — an important place; the center of a city or country	N/A
Weak — the opposite of strong; without strength	**Week** — a group of seven days	N/A
Bare — sparse, lacking, or without	**Bear** — a large, furry animal that is typically hostile	To bear: expressing an object or emotion
Principal — the leader of a school	**Principle** — a rule or ordinance	N/A
Great — better than good	**Grate** — a metal slab with holes	**To grate** — to shred or destroy
Mane: an animal's hair	**Main** — default, most important	**Maine** — an American state
Here — current location	**Hear** — what you do with your ears	N/A
Aloud — to speak out loud or vocalize	**Allowed** — permitted, able to do, not forbidden	N/A
Sell — to put up for	**Cell** — a prison	**Cell** — the smallest unit of

purchase		life
Tail — an animal's body part	**Tale** — a story	N/A
Whether — a choice between two options	**Weather** — changes in the climate and seasons	N/A
Scene — part of a story, play, or movie; an event	**Seen** — something you saw in the past; past tense of seeing	N/A
Mail — written letters or packages	**Male** — refers to gender; a boy; the opposite of female	**To mail** — the process of mailing a letter or package
Knight — a medieval warrior in armor	**Night** — the opposite of dag	N/A
Heel — the end of your foot	**Heal** — to cure or improve the health of	**Hill** — a tall pile or small mountain
Sun — the ball of light in the sky; opposite of the moon	**Son** — the male child of one or more parents	N/A
Blue — a primary color	**Blew** — the past tense of blow	**Blue** — slang for "sad"
Ate — the past tense of "eat"	**Eight** — the number after seven	N/A
Soul — a spirit	**Sole** — the bottom of a shoe	**Sole** — the only one
Steal — to take away unlawfully	**Steel** — a silver colored metal	**Steal** — slang for a good deal
Metal — a strong material	**Mettle** — strength of will or character	**Meddle** — to interfere with
Break — to destroy or damage something	**Brake** — to slow down or stop, typically referring to a car	**To break** — to put on pause, to step away from
Bored — a feeling; meaning uninterested or indifferent	**Board** — a long, thin piece of wood	N/A

Meat — a food that typically comes from animals; can be plant-based in some circumstances (“impossible” meats or tofu)	**Meet** — the act of two or more people heading to the same location	N/A

2 Tone & Voice

This section provides guidance for helping students choose the right tone and point of view to add clarity and engagement to their writing. Tone and voice help readers understand not only *what* is being said, but *how* it is meant to sound. The following guidelines will help students write with confidence and purpose.

2.1 Clarity and Directness

Students should learn to express their ideas in a simple and straightforward way. Clear writing helps readers understand the message quickly. Encourage students to avoid unnecessary words, long phrases, and complicated sentences.

Examples:

- **Wordy**: The reason why I didn't do my homework is because I accidentally left it at my grandma's house.
- **Clear**: I didn't bring my homework because I left it at my grandma's house.

2.2 Audience Appropriate Language

Students should use language that fits a fifth-grade reading level. This means using familiar words and short explanations. Students should also learn to avoid advanced vocabulary unless it has already been taught in class.

Examples:

- **Instead of**: The protagonist experienced significant emotional distress.
- **Use**: The main character was very worried.

2.3 Consistent Point-of-View (POV)

Students should learn to keep the same point-of-view throughout a piece of writing. Shifting between “I,” you,” or “they” can confuse readers. A change in point-of-view should only happen if it is purposeful and clearly communicated.

Examples:

- **Inconsistent:** I love playing basketball because you get to play with your friends.
- **Consistent:** I love playing basketball because I get to play with my friends.

2.4 Emotional Tone

Emotional tone is the feeling a writer creates through word choice. Students should choose a tone that fits the purpose of their writing, and maintain it throughout the piece. A clear emotional tone helps readers understand how the writing is meant to sound.

Examples:

- **Formal tone:** The experiment showed a change in color.
- **Casual tone:** The experiment was really cool!

2.5 Tone for Informative or Descriptive Writing

Informative writing should sound objective and fact-based. Students should focus on sharing only information and facts. They should avoid writing personal thoughts (opinions), emotional phrasing, or persuasive language.

Examples:

- **Not appropriate:** I think volcanoes are super cool!
- **Appropriate:** Volcanoes are openings in Earth’s crust.

2.6 Tone for Persuasive Writing

Persuasive writing should sound confident and convincing. Students should use strong reasons and facts to encourage the reader to agree with them. The tone should stay focused and assertive without being demanding.

Examples:

- **Not persuasive:** I think my idea is the best one. Everyone likes recess.
- **Persuasive:** Students should have longer recess because it helps them stay focused in class.

2.7 Use of Active Voice

The active voice makes sentences stronger, clearer, and easier for readers to understand. In the active voice, the subject does the action. In the passive voice, the action happens *to* the subject. The passive voice can often feel unnatural or awkward. Students should use the active voice whenever possible to keep their writing clear and engaging for the reader.

Examples:

- **Passive:** The soccer ball was kicked by Brady.
- **Active:** Brady kicked the soccer ball.

3 Grammar & Structure Rules

This section introduces rules that will help students build strong sentence structure and use correct grammar. These guidelines support student writers as they learn to communicate their ideas effectively and confidently.

3.1 Subject-Verb Agreement

The subject and verb in a sentence must match in number (singular or plural). This means a singular subject needs a singular verb, and a plural subject needs a plural verb.

Examples:

- **Incorrect:** The dog run around outside.
- **Correct:** The dog runs around outside.

3.2 Clauses and Phrases

Students should use clauses and phrases to connect ideas smoothly and avoid sentence fragments. A **clause** has a subject and a verb. A **phrase** is a group of words that adds information to a sentence, but cannot stand alone.

Examples:

- **Clause + clause:** I finished my homework, **and** I read my book.
- **Clause + phrase:** We walked home **after school.**
- **Incorrect fragment:** Because we were running late.
- **Correction:** We hurried to school because we were running late.

3.3 Transition Words

Transition words help connect ideas between sentences and/or within a sentence. They guide the reader from one thought to another.

Examples:

- **Time transitions:** first, next, later, then, finally
- **Cause/effect transitions:** because, therefore, as a result
- **Contrast transitions:** but, however, although, on the other hand

Sentence examples:

- **Time:** First, we took our dog outside. Then, we gave him a bath.
- **Cause/effect:** We gave our dog a bath because he was covered in mud.
- **Contrast transitions:** It was a hot day, but the water was nice and cold.

3.4 Sentence Variety

Using different types of sentences helps the flow of ideas and makes writing feel more engaging. Students should mix simple, complex, and compound sentences.

Simple sentences:

- A simple sentence has one subject and one verb.
- **Example:** The dog barked.

Complex sentences:

- A complex sentence has one independent clause and one dependent clause.
- **Example:** I finished my chores before I went to bed.

Compound sentences:

- A compound sentence has two independent clauses joined by a conjunction.
- **Example:** We baked cookies, and the whole house smelled delicious.

3.5 Identifying Sentence Types

Students should be able to recognize the four basic sentence types: declarative, interrogative, exclamatory, and imperative sentences. Understanding sentence types helps students to use punctuation correctly.

Declarative:

- A sentence that tells something.
- **Example:** We went to the library on Saturday.

Interrogative:

- A sentence that asks a question.
- **Example:** Did you go to the store?

Exclamatory:

- A sentence that shows strong emotion.
- **Example:** That was an awesome game!

Imperative:

- A sentence that gives a command or request.
- **Example:** Please close the door.

3.6 Fragments vs. Complete Sentences

Every sentence must have a subject and a predicate (a verb that tells what the subject is doing). A group of words that is missing either part is considered a fragment, not a complete sentence. Students should be able to recognize the difference and write in complete sentences.

Examples:

- **Fragment:** Running down the street.
- **Complete:** Our dog was running down the street.

3.7 Spelling Expectations

Students should learn and apply grade-appropriate spelling. They should also learn how to use references like dictionaries to check unfamiliar words.

Examples:

- **Correcting common words:**
  - Incorrect: “freind”
  - Correct: “friend”
- **Using references:**
  - Looking up a word in the dictionary to check spelling
  - Using spell-check tools responsibly

3.8 Domain-Specific Vocabulary

Writers should use precise vocabulary when writing about specific subjects such as math, science, or social studies. This improves the accuracy of a student’s writing.

Examples:

- **Math:** Instead of *times number,* use *factor.*
- **Science:** Instead of *bug,* use *insect.*
- **Social Studies:** Instead of *leader,* use *president.*

3.9 Figurative Language

Students should be able to identify and use common types of figurative language such as metaphors, similes, and idioms. These tools improve the descriptiveness and effect of a student’s writing.

Metaphor:

- A comparison that says one thing *is* something else.
- **Example:** The snow was a blanket.

Simile:

- A comparison using *like* or *as.*

- **Example:** He was as light as a feather.

Idiom:
- A phrase that means something different from the literal words.
- **Example:** She spilled the beans about the surprise party.

3.10 Avoiding Run-Ons and Comma Splices

Students should learn to join ideas correctly using conjunctions, punctuation, or separate sentences.

Run-On:
- A run-on sentence happens when two complete ideas are joined incorrectly.
- **Example:** We wanted to play outside it started raining.

Comma Splice:
- A comma splice occurs when two complete ideas are joined by a comma.
- **Example:** We wanted to play outside, it started raining.

Corrected examples:
- We wanted to play outside, **but** it started raining.
- We wanted to play outside. **However,** it started raining.

3.11 Tense Consistency

When writing, students should stay in the same verb tense unless there is a clear reason to shift. Switching tenses without purpose can cause the writing to become confusing.

Examples:
- **Inconsistent:** Yesterday, we *walked* to the park and *play* on the swings.
- **Consistent (past tense):** Yesterday, we *walked* to the park and *played* on the swings.
- **Consistent (present tense):** Every day, we *walk* to the park and *play* on the swings.

3.12 Number Formatting

Students should learn to follow consistent rules for when to spell out numbers or use numerals. The classroom rules below are a common guideline.

Examples of a typical classroom rule:

- **Spell out** numbers **one through ten:** three apples, seven books
- **Use numerals** for numbers **11 and above:** 12 desks, 25 pencils
- **Always use numerals** for measurements, dates, and time: 3 inches, December 5, 6:30 PM.

4 Punctuation & Mechanics

Punctuation is a system of conventional signs or symbols used in written language to separate sentences and clauses, clarify meaning, and ensure the proper structure and flow of text.

Common punctuation marks include periods (full stops), commas, question marks, exclamation points, colons, semicolons, and quotation marks.

4.1 Correct End Punctuation

The end of a sentence in English is marked by a single terminal punctuation mark. There are only three standard marks used for this purpose:

The Period (.) *(also called a full stop)*

- **Use:** Marks the end of a declarative sentence (a statement) or an imperative sentence (a command). It indicates that the sentence is complete and the tone is neutral.
- **Examples:** The sun rises in the east. Please close the door quietly.

The Question Mark (?) *(also called an interrogation point)*

- **Use:** Marks the end of an interrogative sentence (a direct question). It indicates that the sentence is seeking information.
- **Examples:** What time is the meeting tomorrow? Did you remember your keys?

The Exclamation Point (!) *(also called an exclamation mark)*

- **Use:** Marks the end of a sentence that expresses strong emotion, emphasis, surprise, excitement, or urgency. It gives the sentence a forceful tone.
- **Examples:** That was a fantastic concert! Watch out for the car!

These three are the only standard punctuation marks used to terminate a sentence in formal, modern English writing. Other marks like colons, semicolons, or commas are used internally within sentences, not at the end to signify completion.

Font formatting should always support reading to avoid overwhelming the student.

4.2 Comma Rules

The rules for using commas primarily involve separating elements within a sentence to ensure clarity and structure, rather than indicating a pause for breath.

Separating Items in a Series (lists):

- Use commas to separate three or more words, phrases, or clauses in a list.
- **Example:** We bought apples, peaches, and bananas today.

The Oxford Comma:

- The comma before the final "and" is called the Oxford or serial comma. Its use is a stylistic choice, but is sometimes needed for clarity.
- **Example:** We bought apples, peaches, and bananas today.

After Introductory Elements:

- Use a comma after introductory words, phrases, or clauses.
- **Example:** Because of the car accident, the cake was smashed inside of the box.

With Coordinating Conjunctions:

- Use a comma before FANBOYS (for, and, nor, but, or, yet, so) when joining two independent clauses.
- **Example:** He wanted to kiss her, but he was afraid that she would slap him.

Non-Essential Information:

- Use two commas to set off information that is not essential to the sentence's meaning. There must always be two commas in the sentence, framing the non-essential information.
- **Example:** The chicken, who had been pecking at the ground, ran to the door when she opened it.

Coordinate Adjectives

- Use commas between adjectives that equally describe the same noun.
- **Example:** He bought a dirty, cheap motorcycle.

Dates and Addresses

- Use commas to separate dates and addresses.
- **Examples:**
    - It was March 17, 2015
    - His address was 607 Highline Lane, Smithville, Arkansas.

4.3 Apostrophes: Possession and Contractions

The rules for apostrophes can be divided into two main uses: showing possession and forming contractions (omissions).

Singular Possession

- Add an apostrophe followed by an s ('s), even if the word already ends in s.
- **Example:** The dog's collar is loose.
- **Example:** James's hat is new (or James' hat, depending on style guide, but 's is preferred by many academic styles).

Plural Possession (ending in ‘s’)

- Add only an apostrophe (') after the existing s.
- **Example:** The boys' hands were cold (multiple boys).
- **Example:** The students' scores were high.

Plural Possession (not ending in ‘s’)

- Treat them like singular nouns by adding an apostrophe followed by an s ('s).
- **Example:** The children's game.
- **Example:** The women's team.

Joint Possession

- Place the 's on the last owner's name:
- **Example:** Bill and Ted's guitar (they share one guitar).

Individual Possession

- Place the 's on each name
- **Example:** Bill's and Ted's guitars (each has his own guitar).

Contractions

- Apostrophes are used as placeholders for omitted letters when combining two words into one.
- **Example:** It's cold outside. (It is).
- **Example:** Don't forget your keys. (Do not).
- **Example:** We'll be there soon. (We will).

Possessive Pronouns

- Never use an apostrophe for possessive pronouns (e.g., its, hers, yours, theirs, ours, whose). These words already show possession.
- **Examples:**
    - **Correct:** The dog wagged its tail.
    - **Incorrect:** The dog wagged its' tail.

"Its" vs. "It's" — The Most Common Mistake.

- It's = It is or It has (contraction).
- Its = Belonging to it (possessive pronoun).

Plural Nouns (No Apostrophes)

- Apostrophes almost never make a noun plural.
- **Examples:**
    - **Correct:** We bought three pizzas and two sodas.
    - **Incorrect:** We bought three pizza's and two soda's.

Exception: Pluralizing Letters

- Apostrophes can be used for clarity when pluralizing single lowercase letters.
- **Example:** "Mind your p's and q's".

4.4 Main Uses of Quotation Marks

Quotation marks (" " or ' ') are used to enclose the exact words, phrases, or sentences that have been spoken or written by someone else. They help a reader understand which words belong to the speaker or source, and rather than the writer. Here is a list of the main uses of quotation marks.

- **Direct Quotes and Dialogue**
  - Use quotation marks to signify the beginning and end of direct speech or text copied verbatim from another source.
  - **Example:** She asked, "Are you coming to the party?"
- **Titles of Short Works**
  - Use quotation marks around the titles of smaller creative works that are part of a larger publication (articles, poems, songs, episodes, and book chapters).
  - **Example:** My favorite poem is Robert Frost's "The Road Not Taken."
- **Scare Quotes/Irony**
  - Use quotation marks to indicate that a word is used in a special or ironic way, or that the writer is skeptical of its validity.
  - **Example:** How to use "fresh" bread when it is dried up.
- **Words as Words**
  - Use quotation marks to draw attention to a specific word or letter being discussed as an object itself, rather than for its meaning. (Using italics is also a common alternative for this purpose).
  - **Example:** The word "Colonel" is difficult to spell.
- **Nicknames**
  - Use quotation marks to set apart a nickname when it is placed between a person's first and last name.
  - **Example:** Dwayne "The Rock" Johnson.

Important Rule: Quotation marks always appear in pairs — an opening mark at the start of the quoted material and a closing mark at the end.

4.5 Punctuation with Quotation Marks

Question Marks and Exclamation Points (Conditional Placement)

- These marks go outside the quotation marks if they apply to the entire sentence and not the quoted material itself.
- **Example:** Did you really just say "I don't love you anymore"? (The question is the entire sentence, not the quote.)
- **Example:** I cannot believe the professor said, "There is a test today"! (The exclamation applies to the speaker's disbelief, not necessarily the tone of the quote itself.)

Terminal Punctuation Goes Inside the Quotation Marks

- In standard American English, terminal punctuation marks are placed inside the closing quotation mark.
- **Example (statement):** She simply said, "I'm going home."
- **Example (question):** My father asked me, "Are you finished yet?"
- **Example (exclamation):** The coach yelled, "Run harder!”
    - In these examples, the sentence visually ends with a quotation mark, but the period, question mark, or exclamation point is what officially terminates the sentence structure.

Quoting a Single Word or Phrase at the End of a Sentence

- Even when only quoting a fragment of a sentence (single word or phrase), American English still places the period inside the quotation marks.
- **Example:** To exit, type "quit”.

4.6 Core Rules of Capitalization

Capitalization rules in English apply mainly to the beginning of sentences, the pronoun "I," and proper nouns.

First Word of a Sentence

- Always capitalize the first word of a complete sentence.
- **Example:** The weather was beautiful.

The Pronoun "I"

- The first-person singular pronoun "I" is always capitalized, regardless of its position in the sentence.
- **Example:** She and I went to the store.

Proper Nouns

- Capitalize specific names of people, places, organizations, and things.
- Common nouns (general items) are not capitalized.

4.7 Specific Categories for Capitalization

Names and Titles of People

- Capitalize a person's first, middle, and last name.
    - **Example:** Ava Pearl Jones
- Capitalize titles when they come before a person's name.
    - **Example:** President Biden, General Smith.
- Do not capitalize titles used generally or after a name.
    - **Example:** The president of the company, a general.
- Capitalize family titles (Mom, Uncle) when used as names, but not when preceded by a possessive pronoun (e.g., "my mom").
    - **Example:** I went to Uncle Ben's funeral.
    - **Example:** I saw my uncle's car in the parking lot.

Places and Geography

- Capitalize names of specific countries, cities, states, landmarks, streets, and bodies of water.
    - **Examples:** France, the Empire State Building, the Pacific Ocean.
- Capitalize specific geographic regions.
    - **Examples:** the South, the West Coast.
- Do not capitalize general compass directions.
    - **Example:** Go north for five miles.

Dates, Time Periods, and Events

- Capitalize days of the week, months, and holidays.
    - **Examples:** Monday, January, Christmas.
- Capitalize names of specific historical eras and events
    - **Examples:** the Middle Ages, World War II

- Do not capitalize centuries or seasons
    - **Examples:** the eighteenth century, summer

Languages, Nationalities, and Religions

- Capitalize the names of languages, nationalities, races, and religions.
    - **Examples:** Spanish, American, Christianity.

Institutions and Brands:

- Capitalize the names of specific companies, organizations, schools, and brand names.
    - **Examples:** Google, Harvard University, Nike.

Titles of Works:

- Capitalize the first and last word of a book, article, song, or movie title, as well as all major words (nouns, verbs, adjectives, adverbs, and pronouns) in the title.
    - **Example:** *The World's Most Beautiful Places*
- Lowercase articles (a, an, the), short prepositions (in, on, of, etc.), and coordinating conjunctions (and, but, or) unless they are the first or last word in the title.
    - **Example:** *The Fox in the Hen House*

Direct Quotations:

- Capitalize the first word of a complete direct quote.
    - **Example:** He said, "The case is far from over."
- Do not capitalize partial quotes.
    - **Example:** He said the case was "far from over."

5 Visual & Writing Formatting

Consistency

Visual and writing consistency helps students recognize materials, stay organized, and understand expectations across assignments. The way writing looks on the page can directly affect how well students follow and process the information.

5.1 Choose a Specific Font Format

Font choices should always support readability to avoid overwhelming students.

Teacher guidance:

- Use simple, readable fonts (Arial, Verdana, Times New Roman).
- Keep font sizes between 12–14 pt for printed materials.
- Use bold for headings or key terms.
- Use italics to emphasize titles, thoughts, or variables.
- Maintain the same font choices across student handouts, slides, and digital materials.

Purpose: The goal is to help students focus on content, not struggle with the design.

5.2 Use Clear Headers and Labels

Headers or labels guide students through the structure of the assignment and help them understand expectations.

Teacher guidance:

- Keep heading styles the same across worksheets, activities, and digital work.
- Label sections clearly (e.g., *Introduction, Body, Conclusion, Directions, Example*).
- Avoid excessively decorative or styled headings that can distract from content.
- Maintain consistency between student handouts, slides, and digital materials.

Purpose: Clear labels help students move through content with confidence.

5.3 Keep a Clean Layout With Spacing and Margins

Adequate spacing between content allows students to process information more effectively.

Teacher guidance:

- Use line breaks between sections to separate ideas.
- Give enough space for students to write comfortably.
- Avoid crowding text together to keep instructions visually calm and simple.
- Use consistent margins and alignment across all documents.
- Maintain consistency between student handouts, slides, and digital materials.

Purpose: Sufficient spacing reduces overload and supports all students, especially students with attention or processing needs.

5.4 Avoid Jargon

Students will read more successfully when vocabulary is simple and familiar.

Teacher guidance:

- Use everyday language in directions and assignments.
    - **Example:** Instead of “analyze,” use “look closely at…”
    - **Example:** Instead of “summarize,” use “tell the main points…”
- If a word is new or technical, explain it in a short phrase or parenthesis.

- Provide an example or comparison to help students understand the idea.
- Define words that may be challenging or unfamiliar.

Purpose: Keep wording clear and grade appropriate.

5.5 Be Consistent

Consistency across materials helps students know what to expect and reduces confusion.

Teacher guidance:

- Use the same terms across lessons.
    - **Example:** If you call it “main idea,” don’t switch to “central idea” later.
- Keep heading styles, labels, lists, and terminology consistent in all materials.
- Model consistent paragraph structure in writing samples.

Purpose: When writing follows predictable patterns, students will be successful.

6 Accessibility & Readability

Accessibility ensures that all students can understand classroom materials. Readability focuses on writing that is simple, direct, and grade-appropriate.

6.1 Use Simple, Direct Sentences

Short, clear sentences help students understand what is being asked.

Teacher guidance:

- Write one idea per sentence.
- Remove extra or complicated wording.
- Break long directions into multiple short steps.
- Keep verbs active and clear.

Purpose: Students should immediately understand what to do without reading again.

6.2 Choose Grade-Appropriate Words

Vocabulary should match students' reading level and experience.

Teacher guidance:

- Use familiar words when possible.
- When using academic terms, explain them in grade-appropriate language.
- Avoid figurative expressions or idioms unless you teach them directly.
- Use sentence starters or key terms to support emerging writers.

Purpose: If students can't understand the words, they can't complete the task.

6.3 Avoid Confusing Phrasing

Clear wording helps students work independently.

Teacher guidance:

- Avoid long, complicated sentences.
- Do not include multiple actions in one step.
- Rewrite unclear phrases so students know exactly what to do.
- If there are next steps, make sure to state them clearly.

Purpose: Clear language prevents misunderstandings and reduces frustration.

6.4 Give Step-by-Step Directions

Structured instructions increase success for all students.

Teacher guidance:

- Number steps when possible.
- Keep each step short and direct.
- Provide examples or models, especially for writing assignments.
- Use visuals (icons, arrows, boxes) to show sequences.

Purpose: Clear directions support independence and reduce the need for repeated clarification.

7 Common Errors & Exceptions

7.1 Common Errors and Fixes

(See Section 1.3 for homophone errors and Section 1.1 for core rules and preferred word usage)

Common Error	Correction / Fix
Misspelling Common or Unfamiliar Words Example: “excercise” instead of “exercise”	Provide spell check tools, vocabulary sheets, and dictionaries. Consider adding a classroom spelling chart for common errors.
Improper Punctuation Examples: missing periods, using exclamation marks in formal writing	Review punctuation frequently. Consider allowing students to use built-in AI grammar tools and practice writing sentences to review in class.
Improper Verb Tense Example: “I ated” instead of “I ate” or “I have eaten”	Teach and review verb tenses regularly. Include correct forms in weekly curriculum, spelling tests, and worksheets.
Exaggeration in Formal Writing Example: “This is the greatest class ever!”	Encourage concrete, specific language grounded in facts and observations (“This class is enjoyable since it allows creativity”). Remind students to avoid dramatic phrasing in formal writing.
Excessive Alliteration Example: Starting every sentence with the same sound or structure.	Encourage students to use sentence variety in length and structure. Clarify when alliteration is appropriate and when it is not. Set and review clear expectations.

7.2 Exceptions to Rules

As with any set of rules, there are exceptions that teachers should consider. These exceptions allow for creative freedom and help students understand when rules may be intentionally broken in the appropriate context.

Exceptions to consider in a fifth-grade curriculum:

- **Creative writing may use less formal language.** Specific group terms may not be necessary in fictional writing.
- **Gender-based pronouns** may be used when they are meaningful. This includes referring to a character with gendered pronouns (e.g., she/her, he/him) or quoting a real person accurately in informational writing.
- **Contractions** are acceptable in non-formal writing. Students may use contractions in journals or other casual writing.
- **Non-correlative conjunctions** can be used with the intention to show or explain why they are improper.
- **Formal, concluding statements** are not required in creative or non-formal writing such as stories, poems, and other personal writing.
- **Exaggeration and alliteration** are sometimes appropriate in creative writing when used thoughtfully.

References

Common Core English Language Arts Standards — Grade 5
A reference for the grammar, writing, and language standards used throughout this guide.

Fifth Grade English Language Arts Common Core State Standards
Another reference for the grammar, writing, and language standards used throughout this guide.

Technical Writer Style Guide Overview
This reference provides examples of formatting and structure used in professional style guides.

Design Language Principles
This reference supports visual consistency and layout recommendations.

EIA Writing Style Guide
This is a professional-level punctuating and formatting reference guide.

Capitalization Rules: When Do Words Need To Be Capitalized?
A reference used to support capitalization guidelines.